

EARNING THE RIGHT

I've been doing this long enough to know what I'm worth.

Long enough that my hands don't feel heat the way yours do. Long enough that my body keeps score in ways I stopped noticing years ago. Long enough that I've stopped counting the kitchens, the covers, the chefs who broke me down and the ones I broke down in return.

So when someone tells me they can cook, I listen.

And then I wait for the punchline.

Because it's always coming. It's always some version of: "I made a risotto once and it turned out great." Or: "My partner does this amazing Thai curry." Or my personal favourite: "My Mum's the best cook I know."

I get it. You think you can do what I do.

But here's the thing—you can't.

There are countless differences between my cooking environment and yours. My kitchen stove top does not have a "Save As" button, okay? If I fuck up in the kitchen, that's it. There's no undo, there's no: "Oh well, the guests will understand."

Guests will NEVER understand. Nor do they appreciate that I can cook a steak to medium rare, every time. Because when my guest is paying fifty-eight dollars for that steak, do you really think they're going to be satisfied when it's not right? A simple: "Oh that's okay love, medium rare, give or take a few degrees." They may as well be saying: "Here, while you're at it take my wallet and the keys to my Mercedes E350... And I'm an understanding, laid-back guy—of course you may fuck my wife."

You just sit in your cushy little household kitchen with your nine-hundred-dollar KitchenAid that you have only mustered how to whisk in, and casually stress over trying to pull the garlic bread up at the same time as Donna Hay's Pasta a la Primavera without everything going stodgy and cold for your five other guests who will probably still accept you at least as a casual acquaintance even if it is only for a Christmas party invite—sadly, my reviewers are not the same.

I'll have seven pans going, three of them bipolar and temperamental sauces, two fish in the oven, a salad to prep, all while watching the kitchen hand with one eye who keeps wiping the plates clean with a tea towel without actually washing them—whilst not forgetting that table seven is half gluten-free even though it's not on the docket, and tables thirty-four, seventeen, and three are coming up on mains all at once because front of house are cunts.

No worries, mate.

But it's even different for us chefs at home. I guarantee you, when I make a meal it's all: "Thanks handsome man, please pass the potatoes." But you bet your arse if my girl is cooking for me, I better act like she's single-handedly built the Great Wall of China, blindfolded, with nothing more than a toothpick and some intuition.

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But as far as your Mum being the best chef you know—shush, just stop it. Your Mum might be the best cook in the world, for sure. Hell, my mother makes the best bbq chicken I have ever tasted. And my Dad? Well... he wasn't much of a cook, but his curried sausages. I can guarantee you, it can't be beaten. So I do believe you when you say your half-Lebanese mother makes the best... I don't know, falafel. Whatever—my point is, they make it for you. They make it for your brothers and sisters and family friends.

They don't make it every single night, for fifty-five or one hundred and five covers, plated perfectly, cooked perfectly, over and over, repeatedly and consistently—and fast.

My Dad can't do that. Do you know WHY he can't do that?

Because he's a fucking Cabinet Maker, not a chef.

"No one is born a great cook, one learns by doing." — Julia Child

I like that quote. I like to think that the techniques I have repeated day in and out for however many years mean something. I like to think that what we do is kind of like porn. You can watch it, be fascinated by it, it will entice your intrigue and tickle your curiosity—but try it at home, it won't look or sound nearly the same or as satisfying, and the majority of you are sensible enough to realise that it's probably not wise to try and act it out.

You can like cooking all you want. It doesn't mean it will like you back.

And it's the little things that make us different. For example:

- I can chop without looking.
- I don't follow a recipe. I laugh at recipes. I look at them, study them, then laugh at them and think: "Well fuck, that's not gonna happen—I'm doing it this way."
- I can pick up a piece of confit duck with my bare hands. It doesn't bother me one bit; I lost all feeling in them years ago anyway. The sensation in my index finger is left with the skin that is now attached to the grill of my first job. There it shall remain.
- We don't have Band-Aids; we have masking tape.
- Where my palms once were, I now have scars and calluses.
- I don't have an eight o'clock reservation for two at a delightful little wine bar with my significant other—I have a second sitting, a headache, and I'm running out of leeks.

Do you see me walking up to a neurosurgeon suggesting that: "Hey, I played Operation as a kid. I can do this shit too."

No. I'm not that fucking stupid.

So please. Stop trying to patronise me and my fellow industry comrades by telling me you can do what I do. You can't. And when you try, you just look like an idiot.

When you try—you do things like go on MasterChef.

And mate, I've got the popcorn ready.

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But here's the thing about confidence like this—it doesn't come free.

You don't walk into your first kitchen with opinions. You walk in with nothing. Less than nothing. You walk in as the problem everyone has to work around until you figure out how to stop being one.

And if you're lucky—really lucky—you find someone brutal enough to turn you into something useful.

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There's a moment when you stop being the problem.

No one tells you it's happened. There's no ceremony. No one pulls you aside and says congratulations, you're not a liability anymore. It just happens—slowly, invisibly—until one day you realise you're not waiting to be told what to do. You just know. And you do it.

Months passed like that.

Services blurred into each other. Prep lists got shorter—not because there was less to do, but because I could do it faster. The panic that used to rise in my chest when the docket rail started filling? Gone. Replaced by something else entirely—a tightness, an electricity, the kind of nervous energy that sharpens everything instead of blurring it. The rush. The thing you can't explain to anyone who hasn't felt it. The reason people stay.

I learned things I didn't know I was learning.

How to read a kitchen by sound alone—the rhythm of the pans, the pitch of Chef's voice, the silence that meant someone was in the shit. How to move through a crowded pass without touching anyone, without breaking the flow. How to taste something and know, instantly, what it needed—more acid, less salt, another minute on the heat.

None of it came from a textbook. It came from repetition. From fucking up and fixing it. From watching people who were better than me and absorbing everything I could.

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The vineyard kitchen had a way of stripping you down.

Not cruelly—though it could feel that way in the moment. Just... honestly. You couldn't hide in a kitchen that small, with standards that high. Every weakness got exposed. Every gap in your knowledge got found. And either you filled those gaps or you left.

A lot of people left.

I watched them go—the ones who couldn't handle the hours, the ones who wilted under pressure, the ones who thought they wanted this life until they actually lived it. Some lasted a few months. Some lasted days. One guy made it to his third service, walked out mid-ticket, and never came back for his knife roll.

I understood. I did.

This job asks for everything. Your time, your body, your relationships, your sleep. It takes and takes and the only thing it gives back is the work itself—the chance to do it again tomorrow, maybe a little better than you did it today.

For some people, that's not enough.

For me, it was becoming everything.

It was everything.

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I think about those early days and the lessons learnt sometimes.

Not with nostalgia—kitchens don't really allow for that. More like... recognition. The understanding that everything I am now started in that kitchen. Every instinct, every standard, every opinion I hold about what food should be and how a brigade should run—it all traces back to those fluorescent lights, that relentless heat, those people who taught me without ever calling it teaching.

Chef, who could end a conversation with a look and whose silence was the closest thing to approval you'd ever get. Three years I worked under him. I could count the compliments on one hand and still have fingers left.

Marco, quiet and methodical, who could break down a whole animal faster than anyone I've ever seen and never once made it look impressive.

The dishies, holding the whole operation together from the back corner, never getting the credit they deserved.

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Over the years, I've collected lessons.

Some from Chef. Some from Sam. Some from burnt fingers and broken bodies and nights I should've walked away but didn't.

I call them ChefTips.

They're numbered but not by when I learned them. By how much they cost. The higher the number, the cheaper the lesson.

So here they are. Ten ChefTips.

I'll even give you one for free you're gonna need it if you want to survive this industry.